

Level of Awareness on Cultural Diversity and Cultural Thinking Skills Among Senior High School Students in San Pablo City

Niño Lito Jake S. Briones*

[For affiliations and correspondence, see the last page.](#)

Abstract

This study aimed to determine the relationship between the Level of Awareness on Cultural Diversity and Cultural Thinking Skills among Senior High School Students in San Pablo City. It sought to answer the following: What are the profiles of respondents as to age, birth order, gender, sexual preferences, family structure, religion, place of residence, socio-economic status, and ethnicity? To what extent are cultural diversity factors observed to respondents regarding values, beliefs, traditions, and practices? What is the level of observation in cultural thinking skills regarding intercultural engagement, cultural understanding, and intercultural communication? Is there a relationship between the profile of the respondents and cultural thinking skills? Is there a relationship between cultural diversity and cultural thinking skills among senior high school students? Three hundred thirty-six students from 5 public senior high schools participated. Results revealed that respondents were between 16 – 18 years old, females, first-born, and straight in sexual preferences. Most were from nuclear families, Catholic, lived in urban barangays, belonged to the low-income class and Tagalog was the major ethnic group. The level of awareness on cultural diversity concerning values and practices were evaluated as Observed while beliefs and traditions were assessed as Moderately Observed. The respondents' cultural thinking skills, intercultural engagement, cultural understanding, and intercultural communication were observed. Gender and place of residence correlate with cultural understanding, while socio-economic status correlates with intercultural engagement. There's a correlation between the level of awareness of cultural diversity and the cultural thinking skills of the respondents.

Keywords: Cultural Diversity, Cultural Thinking, Awareness, Senior High School Students, Philippines

Introduction

Every Filipino aspires to lead a long and healthy life. Most Filipino children and teenagers will tell you, "Gusto ko yumaman (I want to be rich)" if you ask them about their aspirations on the street. Extreme poverty, social injustice, and inequality are at the heart of this dream's origin. Every Filipino has adopted this way of thinking because these issues remain unaddressed in today's society. It became a way of life in the Philippines, and it's passed down through the generations. The Filipino dream shifts from an individualistic one to a more collective one. Identifying the Filipino culture and shared values to create well-targeted plans and effective policies that can bring about positive changes (National Economic and Development Authority, 2019).

In addition, Filipinos must be culturally competent to understand one another and build harmonious relationships to improve their living conditions and move beyond the current situation. As a result, in all its forms and manifestations, culture is an essential element of long-term development (UNESCO, 2010).

There is still a growing need for a better understanding of how diverse the Filipino culture is despite all the

progress made. Ernesto M. Pernia, the country's socioeconomic planning secretary, said Filipinos are culturally diverse and challenging to define. As a controversial and open-ended term, "cultural diversity" generally refers to the reality of human beings living side by side with people of a wide range of different backgrounds and perspectives on everything from politics to philosophy to religion to language to abilities and disabilities to ethnicities and races to nationalities to sexual orientations (Lin2019). With its guidance counselors and teachers at the helm, the school serves as a bridge of hope and unity for Filipinos in the face of so many challenges associated with cultural diversity.

According to Philippine Department of Education Secretary Leonor Briones, cultural diversity in schools can help students thrive in fields that resonate with the Filipino identity. To foster a more culturally diverse Filipino community, the Philippine Department of Education has committed to promoting multilingual proficiency in the mother tongue as part of the K-12 education program (Montemayor 2019). In addition, the department's commitment to diversity and inclusion is demonstrated by the senior high school's provision of a variety of academic and vocational options that are specifically tailored to the

demographics and resources of the local area.

Filipinos need to consider cultural diversity that includes race, ethnicity, religion, language, economic status, sexual orientation that can influence someone's insights, outlook, and behaviors to foster cultural awareness.

Government schools, institutions, and agencies are non-stop promoting cultural diversity and inclusiveness through their programs and policies to build a better community with a mutual and shared understanding of one another. Because of this, there is a need to improve our approach and consciousness in cultural diversity. Educators, Mental Health Professionals, Sociologists, and other Behavioral Scientists have all the resources to help the Filipino learners develop their cultural thinking skills through intercultural engagement, cultural understanding, and intercultural communication.

Regarding the circumstances being discussed, this study attempted to use the level of consciousness on cultural diversity to help and understand how students increase their cultural thinking skills to deal with gaps in sensitivity to differences of one another and express their interests.

Research Questions

This study attempted to determine the relationship between the level of awareness of cultural diversity and cultural thinking skills among senior high school students. Specifically, it sought to answer the following:

1. To what extent do the cultural diversity factors are observed in senior high school students:
 - 1.1 values;
 - 1.2 beliefs;
 - 1.3 traditions; and
 - 1.4 practices?
2. What is the perceived level of observation in cultural thinking skills in terms of:
 - 2.1 intercultural engagement;
 - 2.2 cultural understanding; and
 - 2.3 intercultural communication?
3. Is there a significant relationship between the profile of the respondents and cultural thinking skills?
4. Is there a significant relationship between cultural diversity and cultural thinking skills among senior high school students?

Methodology

Research Design

This study used correlational research that measures two variables and evaluates the statistical relationship (i.e., the correlation) between them with little or no effort to control extraneous variables (Chiang, 2015). Data collection and analysis were utilized. The quantitative data were derived from the respondents' scores regarding intercultural engagement, cultural understanding, and intercultural communication. The relationship and the status of the research variables provided served as a basis for all senior high school students to understand cultural diversity.

Respondents of the Study

This study involved 336 Students from 5 Public Senior High Schools in San Pablo City, Laguna, enrolled during the school year 2020 – 2021. Students were given self-made questionnaires that they could access through Google forms on the internet since it was conducted during the Covid-19 pandemic. The safety of the respondents was highly considered.

Research Instrument

The researcher constructed a computer-delivered self-administered questionnaire to meet the relevant data to reach the respondents. The advantages of a self-administered questionnaire are low cost, ease in locating respondents, saving time, respondents' convenience, greater anonymity, and less chance of biasing error, according to iedunote.com (2020). The contents of the questionnaire were based on the personal knowledge of the researcher and were validated by a panel of experts in the field. This includes cultural diversity questions about values, beliefs, practices, traditions, and ethnicity. Also, cultural thinking skills, including intercultural engagement, cultural understanding, and intercultural communication.

Research Procedure

The researcher wrote a letter that asked permission from the different schools that allowed the researcher to administer the computer-delivered self-administered questionnaire among senior high school students of 5 Public Senior High Schools in San Pablo City.

The computer-delivered self-administered questionnaire was distributed among the respondents through Google forms since the researcher needs to adapt the new normal to answer the required information. After which, the researcher recovered the questionnaires, tallied, computed, interpreted, and analyzed using statistical tools.

Statistical Treatment of Data

This study applied descriptive statistics like frequency, percentage, standard deviation, and means to determine the scores of senior high school students using cultural diversity factors to find an association with cultural thinking skills. Pearson correlation was also used to determine the relationship between cultural diversity and cultural thinking skills.

Results and Discussion

Cultural Diversity

The statistical table on this part contained the level of awareness on cultural diversity: values, beliefs, traditions, and practices perceived by the respondents.

Table 1. *Summary of Observed Level of Awareness on Cultural Diversity*

<i>Cultural Diversity</i>	<i>Mean</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>Verbal Interpretation</i>
Values	4.13	0.63	Observed
Beliefs	3.18	1.01	Moderately Observed
Traditions	3.29	0.89	Moderately Observed
Practices	3.94	0.59	Observed
Overall	3.64	0.78	Observed

Table 1 manifest that overall mean is 3.64 and is categorized as Observed (O). It shows the comprehensive representation of the level of awareness of the cultural diversity of the respondents. It implies that values, beliefs, traditions, and practices are still visible and conscious to the respondents and help them shape their behavior, personality, and thinking capabilities. The highest mean among cultural diversity factors is valued with a mean level of 4.13 and categorized as Observed (O).

Cultural Thinking Skills

The statistical table presented contains the cultural thinking skills: intercultural engagement, cultural understanding, and intercultural communication.

Table 2. *Summary of the observed level of Cultural Thinking Skills*

<i>Cultural Thinking Skills</i>	<i>Mean</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>Verbal Interpretation</i>
Intercultural Engagement	3.87	0.71	Observed
Cultural Understanding	4.16	0.61	Observed
Intercultural Communication	3.84	0.78	Observed
Overall	3.96	0.70	Observed

Test of Correlation between Variables

Table 3 shows the correlation between values and cultural thinking skills of senior high school students. It implied that values have a significant factor in relating with other people, improving students' skills in engaging, accepting, or understanding and communicating with different people, and being aware or connected with their environment.

Table 3. *Correlation between Values and Cultural Thinking Skills*

	<i>Intercultural Engagement</i>	<i>Cultural Understanding</i>	<i>Intercultural Communication</i>
1. Using "Mano Po"	.346"	.374"	.325"
2. Utilizing "Po" and "Opo"	.318"	.343"	.306"
3. Strong Family Ties	.310"	.332"	.294"
4. Sharing	.386"	.357"	.379"
5. Resilience	.337"	.339"	.324"
6. Optimism	.393"	.343"	.376"
7. Humour	.395"	.345"	.353"
8. Celebratory	.424"	.320"	.357"
9. Admiration on Art	.333"	.337"	.364"

The majority of the respondents were from the nuclear family, wherein both parents are involved in taking care of their children, and that also included the essential values of Filipino families instilled in their minds. Furthermore, the more students are responsive to their values, the more they develop things and skills creatively and innovatively.

Values are principles, morals, standards, and ideals that we consider dear and precious in our life (Macaranas & Macaranas 2017), and they help us mold our manner of approach or even in dealing with different cultural setups. It gives us the confidence to relate ourselves to other people or crowds.

Table 4. *Correlation between Beliefs and Cultural Thinking Skills*

	Intercultural Engagement	Cultural Understanding	Intercultural Communication
1. Turning clothes inside out when lost	.210**	.192**	.210**
2. Dropping utensils and someone will come	.157**	.220**	.117*
3. Pointing fingers at night as a sign of bad luck	.200**	.232**	0.086
4. Jumping during New Year's Eve to get taller	.217**	.238**	.190**
5. If someone is lying down, do not walk over them	.226**	.295**	.203**
6. Taking picture with 3 people, someone will die.	.190**	.135*	.148**
7. Choosing an alphabet letter whenever I bite my tongue	.280**	.213**	.213**
8. Sleeping while still hungry, and your spirit will fly far away from your body.	.232**	.130*	.120*
9. Making noise during New Year's Eve to drive away evil spirits	.283**	.265**	.307**

The data above revealed a correlation between the respondents' beliefs and cultural thinking skills. Whether actual or not, it involves those beliefs to the respondents and still considers it a tool for them to relate to other people.

Being aware of beliefs, those respondents allow themselves to experience being part of the indigenous community. It also gave them approval and contentment that helped them be part of a specific cultural community before their groups. Some Filipino beliefs are not relevant today due to technological advancement and modernization. The respondents still considered this in having skills that can help them feel connected to everyone. It also builds self-worth that allows them to thrive by recognizing their own beliefs.

Millennials still consider the power of superstitions and beliefs based on their experiences, the traditions of their old ones, or even their ancestors (Besa 2021). It is also explained by Baltes et al. (2015) in their study that suggests those students' attitudes on inclusive relations had changed significantly, and students talked to and mixed with students from different cultural conditions more after the action.

Table 5. *Correlation between Traditions and Cultural Thinking Skills*

	Intercultural Engagement	Cultural Understanding	Intercultural Communication
1. Celebration or Fiesta	.216**	.275**	.238**
2. Kissing hands	.359**	.292**	.276**
3. Bayanihan or Community Engagement	.470**	.259**	.378**
4. Competitive singing during celebration	.381**	.265**	.374**
5. Start of Christmas Celebration during September	.345**	.264**	.316**
6. Christmas Carol	.308**	.221**	.223**
7. Wearing of Barong Tagalog	.275**	.180**	.271**

Based on the table above, traditions are also an aspect that respondents consider that helped to enhance their cultural thinking skills. It involved those traditions that passed from generation to generation.

Respondent's awareness of different traditions helps them connect in the past and the people around them. It binds and contributes to a harmonious environment that understands the demands of one another. Based on the data above, it is also revealed that being conscious of the traditions of one place or community helped them be part of it. The more respondents absorbed and observed all of these, the more tendency and adjustment in the approach can be more put into action.

Traditions also give color to the way of life that the respondents have. It also helps to understand that more respondents can quickly familiarize themselves through positive attitudes and behavior brought by traditions and allowing them to relate, transmit, and communicate with one another. Bandala (2018) also highlighted that for the tourists visiting towns, fiestas replicate the residents' positive life, overlooking all challenges to be grateful for the finer things in life.

Table 6. *Correlation between Practices and Cultural Thinking Skills*

	Intercultural Engagement	Cultural Understanding	Intercultural Communication
1. Filipino time	.271**	.263**	.244**
2. Avoiding confrontation	.368**	.319**	.318**
3. Being religious and superstitious	.460**	.390**	.432**
4. Using spoon and fork	.248**	.279**	.178**
5. Enjoying asking someone if they eat already	.228**	.286**	.227**
6. Inviting someone to join eating a meal or snack	.318**	.337**	.286**
7. Eating rice in every meal	0.106	.162**	.136*
8. Removing slippers or shoes before entering the house	.205**	.266**	.194**
9. Taking off the hat before entering the house	.313**	.253**	.270**

The data above shows that practices significantly correlate in developing cultural thinking skills, intercultural engagement, cultural understanding, and intercultural communication. Respondents acknowledge that they can blend easily without hesitation inhabits and mannerisms when these practices are learned.

These practices make the respondents more equipped to deal with differences and similarities in certain cultural conditions. It is also implied that these practices helped respondents realize their potential in engaging, understanding, and communicating with people from different cultural backgrounds.

Respondents are also equipped with practices that can quickly adopt specific expertise to create a balanced and well-adjusted environment between the people and the community. Being aware of customary practices can also enhance our cultural sensitivity.

Table 7. *Relationship between the Profile of the Respondents and Cultural Thinking Skills*

	Intercultural Engagement	Cultural Understanding	Intercultural Communication
Age	0.031	0.009	0.021
Birth order	-0.068	-0.006	-0.105
Gender	-0.047	-.155**	-0.028
Sexual orientation	-0.041	0.048	0.006
Family Structure	-0.065	0.008	-0.090
Religion	-0.004	0.062	-0.001
Place of residence	-0.077	-.138*	-0.044
Socio-economic status	.128*	0.075	0.069
Ethnicity	0.014	0.000	0.020

The table illustrates the relationship between the profile of the respondents and cultural thinking skills.

The result revealed that gender, residence, and socio-economic status have a significant correlation. There is a weak inverse correlation between gender and cultural understanding of the respondents, with a score of -.155. Based on the profile of respondents, a large number of sexual preferences were straight, which means that the level of separation and distinction on how respondents observed cultural understanding in the spectrum of their identity. It means that it has exceptional skills that set them apart and correspond and reach out in its environment.

Regarding the place of residence, it also has a weak inverse correlation with cultural understanding, with a score of -.138. It implies that although all the respondents came from one city, there is still a different minor orientation between urban and rural barangays. Since San Pablo City comprises more than 80 barangays classified into urban and rural areas, it is noticeable that understanding one another still has a different standpoint where respondents are part of it.

A score of .128 indicates that socioeconomic status is associated with intercultural engagement. According to Ishii & Eisen (2020), people with lower socioeconomic status have been shown to have a more remarkable ability to understand the emotions of others and a tendency to act altruistically, which is similar to what they found in their research.

Overall, the result revealed no significant relationship between cultural thinking skills and the profile of the

respondents.

Table 8. *Relationship between Cultural Diversity and Cultural Thinking Skills*

	Intercultural Engagement	Cultural Understanding	Intercultural Communication
Values	.545**	.466**	.461**
Beliefs	.317**	.282**	.212**
Traditions	.477**	.331**	.400**
Practices	.479**	.433**	.412**

The table shows the significant correlation between the level of awareness of cultural diversity with cultural thinking skills. It implies that being mindful of values, beliefs, traditions, and practices is significantly related to how they think about intercultural engagement, cultural understanding, and intercultural communication. This may be attributed to the geographical location of San Pablo City, which is within the boundaries of Batangas and Quezon. It has diverse citizens from different family orientations and upbringing of rural and urban barangays and has different socio-economic backgrounds that contribute to the diverse culture adopted by every San Pabloño and become the way of life.

It also implies that upholding awareness and bond with diverse cultures can prevent people from rising prejudices in life. It allows them to empathize and empathize with people different from themselves since they are more aware of the events that someone of a cultural set-up may look at. It also gives the feeling that is expressed to various opinions; people also become open-minded to new ideas and perspectives with a great intellectual capacity on a topic by taking in different points of view. It is similar to the study conducted by Sparkman et al. (2017), which suggests that exposure to inclusive environments can enhance intercultural attitudes by personality transfers in openness to experience.

Data also show that respondents who are conscious of cultural diversity during their learning experience feel more comfortable and safer with differences later in life. In addition, learners who are open to variety and learn cultural awareness in the classroom set them up to grow in the workforce. It is also similar to the study conducted by Baltes et al. (2015), which suggests that students' attitudes in different cultural setups and relations had changed significantly, and students talked to and mixed with students from different cultural backgrounds more after the action.

Furthermore, teenagers are also open to various media that affect how they interact and socialize with other people.

Conclusions

The findings collected together in the study led to the formulation of the following conclusions:

1. The study revealed that between the profile of the respondents and cultural thinking skills, only gender and place of residence have a weak inverse correlation with cultural understanding. In contrast, socioeconomic status has a weak positive correlation with intercultural engagement, and the rest does not correlate. Therefore, the null hypothesis proposed in the study is partially sustained.
2. The study revealed a significant relationship between the level of awareness of cultural diversity and cultural thinking skills. Therefore, the null hypothesis proposed in the survey is not sustained.

Recommendations

The study revealed that the level of awareness of the cultural diversity of the learners had a significant association with cultural thinking skills. In the light of the outcome and conclusions of the study, the following recommendations are given:

1. Learners may consider the importance of being aware of how they expand skills when they are with people from different cultural environments and utilize it to have an atmosphere that can help them develop their mutual respect and understanding.
2. Teachers should also use cultural diversity as a guiding tool to design and plan accommodating learning student-centered learning strategies that provide long-term awareness. They may also consider the use of culturally relevant performance assessments to measure students' learning genuinely.
3. With the rise of migration and globalization in our country, parents may pay attention to the needed assistance and usual support for their children in a diverse environment. Giving them chances to improve cultural skills that can relate to everyone.
4. For future researchers, it is suggested to consider cultural diversity as a factor to

determine the behavior and personality since it drives creativity and innovation.

5. The School Administrators may consider the importance of learning programs and even learning materials that are culturally fitted for everyone.
6. The curriculum specialists may include in their program the advantage of using cultural diversity in teaching different subjects and improving their institutional curricula to achieve good learning outcomes.
7. It is also recommended to replicate this study covering enormous scope in cultural diversity.

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Affiliations and Corresponding Information

Corresponding: **Niño Lito Jake S. Briones**
Affiliation: **Manila Central University - Philippines**
Email: **ninolitojake@gmail.com**